ONLINE STORE · VEHICLE WORKFLOW GUIDE

Part 6

Selling and managing: payments, delivery, updates, support, pre-orders

The part of the business that is not Blender. Setting up the storefront provider, packaging a product so it installs cleanly, shipping updates without breaking anyone, answering support, running greenlight pre-orders, naming things so no railroad's lawyer writes to you, and what the money looks like after fees and tax.

In this part

1. Setting up the storefront provider
2. Packaging a product: installer, versioning, readme
3. Shipping updates without breaking anyone
4. Support that does not eat your week
5. Pre-orders, greenlight thresholds and memberships
6. Names, logos, liveries: the legal playbook
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8. The e-mail list
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Money and legal figures in this part are quoted from the opportunity analysis you supplied (a U.S., Texas-based sole proprietor) and are planning estimates, not advice. Confirm fees on the provider's pricing page (check) and tax rates with an accountant before you file.

1 · Setting up the storefront provider

Part 1 recommended a hosted creator store (route A) for the launch. Whichever one you choose, the set-up is the same seven steps and takes an afternoon.

1. **Account and payout.** Sign up under the studio name; connect the bank account or PayPal; fill in the tax form (W-9 for a U.S. seller). Switch on any “collect sales tax / VAT for me” option: that makes the provider the merchant of record. check
2. **Store page branding.** Upload the logo and set the accent colour so it matches the landing site; set the store address to `store.yourstudio` (Part 5 §3).
3. **One product per vehicle or route.** Title in the design-name form (§6), the same images as the product page, the short pitch, the price. Mark it a digital product.
4. **Upload the file** (§2). Providers keep every file you upload; use the versioned name so you can tell them apart later.
5. **Licence text.** Paste your EULA (one page: personal use, no redistribution of the paid files, textures open for community repaints, no refunds after download except where law requires).
6. **Discount codes and bundles.** Create a launch code and, when you have two related products, a bundle; both are a few clicks.
7. **Test purchase.** Set the price to $0 or use the provider's test mode, buy it yourself, follow the e-mail, download, install. Then set the real price.

2 · Packaging a product: installer, versioning, readme

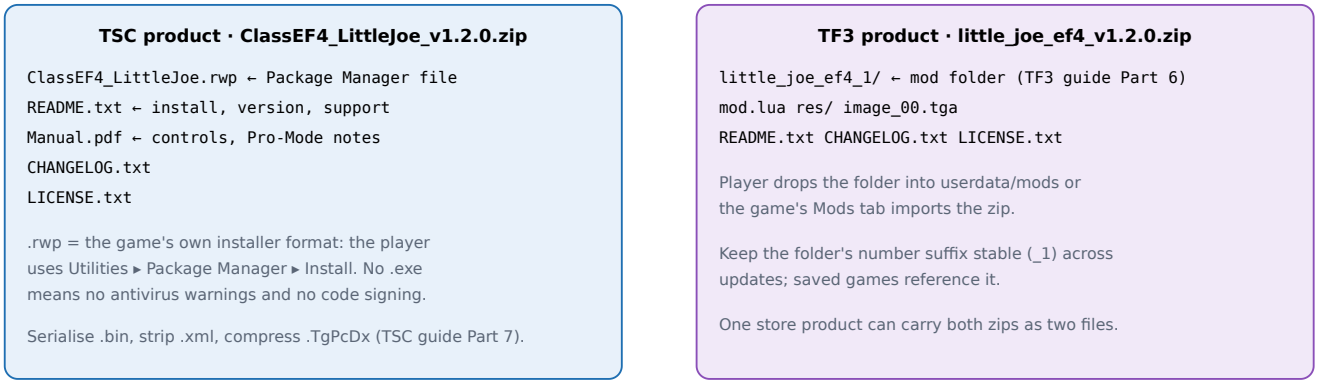


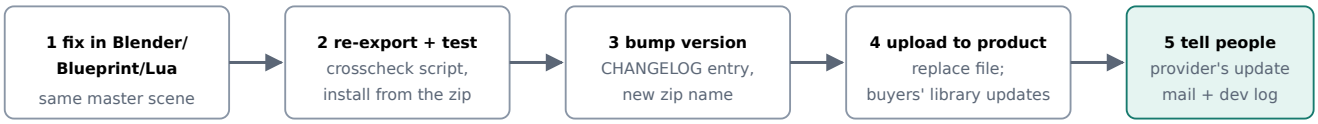
Figure 6.1 · What the buyer actually downloads. Each game has its own native package; both go in the same product with a plain readme on top. The version number is in the file name so support e-mails can quote it.

Version number	Change it when
1.x.x · major	Saves or scenarios break, or the product is re-made (new model, new sim). Players expect to reinstall.
x.**2**.x · minor	New features: a new livery, a new script mode, extra scenarios. Drop-in over the old version.

Version number	Change it when
x.x.**3** · patch	Fixes only. Always safe to install.

> **The readme is the support ticket you never get**
>
> Five lines: which game version it needs, how to install, where the manual is, what to send when it breaks (TSC: the LogMate log; TF3: `stdout.txt`), and the version. Put the same five lines on the product page.

3 · Shipping updates without breaking anyone



Every buyer's library (the “Personal Depot”) shows the new version and a re-download link; most providers can e-mail all buyers of a product in one click.

Figure 6.2 · The update loop. Because the provider keeps the buyer list and the library, an update is “replace file, press notify”.

- **Never rename** blueprint paths, the TF3 mod folder suffix, or the product's provider ID; these are what saves, scenarios and libraries point at.
- **Keep the previous zip** attached to the product for a month so anyone whose scenario broke can roll back.
- **Batch fixes** into a patch every two to four weeks unless something is unplayable; frequent tiny updates train buyers to ignore update mail.
- **Changelog in plain words** (“pantograph no longer clips the roof in the cab view”), not internal names.

4 · Support that does not eat your week

Rule	How
One channel	A support e-mail address (or the provider's message button). A Discord is fine for community, but tell people bugs go to e-mail so nothing is lost in chat.
Ask for the log first	Autoreply template: game version, product version, what happened, attach the log (TSC: LogMate; TF3: stdout.txt). Half the tickets solve themselves.
Public FAQ	Every question answered twice becomes an FAQ entry on the docs page: install steps, “missing assets” (required DLC), cab controls, repaints.
Refunds	State the policy on every product page; the provider handles the money. A quick refund for a genuine incompatibility costs less than an argument.

Rule	How
Support window	Answer within two working days; say so. Batch support into one slot per day instead of reacting.
Known-issues list	On the product page, dated. It stops duplicate reports and shows the product is alive.

5 · Pre-orders, greenlight thresholds and memberships

The opportunity analysis proposes two funding models that both start from the interactive viewer. Both are built from features the storefront providers already have (pre-orders, memberships), so they are configuration, not code.

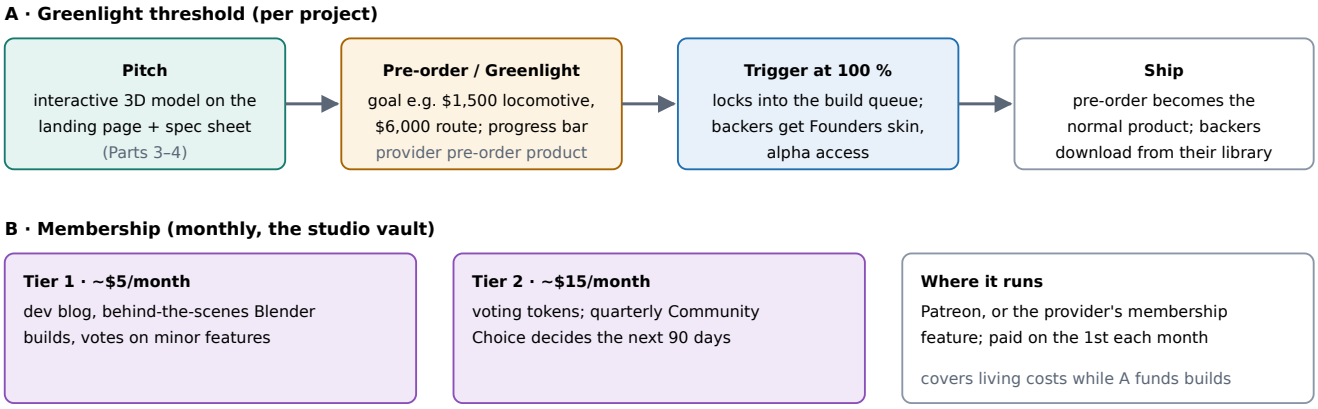


Figure 6.3 · Two funding models from the analysis. A finances individual vehicles; B finances you. They combine: members see the pitch first and get a backer discount.

> **The golden rule from the analysis**
>
> Launch any pre-order with a *working* proof: the free “Proving Ground” demo route or a free demo vehicle that shows the scripted systems running in the real game. The interactive web model proves the art; the demo proves the code. Backers trust what they have already driven.

Money arrives	When	Notes
Provider pre-orders	2–3 business days per sale	Charged at order; refundable until shipped. Say the target date and the fallback.
Kickstarter-style campaign	~14 days after the campaign ends	All-or-nothing; good for one flagship route, heavy on video and updates.
Membership	1st of every month	Predictable; needs a steady stream of posts (the dev log you keep anyway).

6 · Names, logos, liveries: the legal playbook

Part 2 §5 gave the naming table. The reasoning, in one figure, so you can apply it to a product the table does not list.

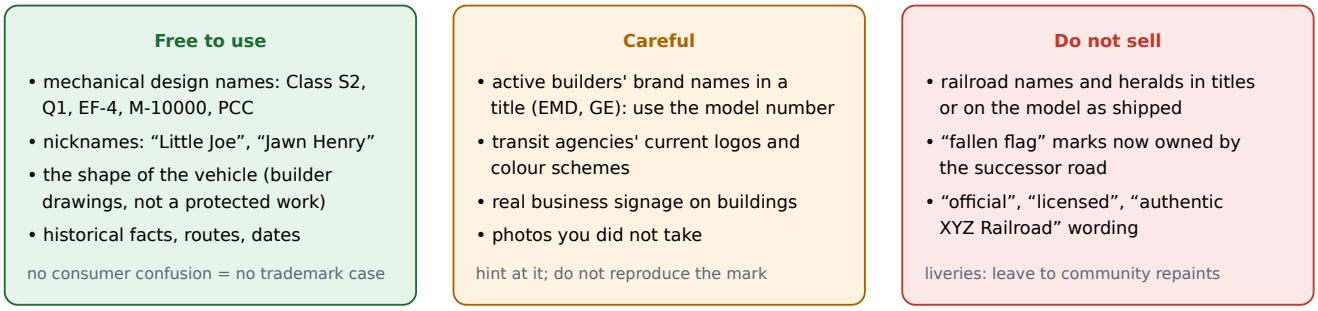


Figure 6.4 · The three bins. Everything you sell lives in the left bin. The NOTICE footnote on every product page (Part 2) says so in writing and tells the community the UV layout is open for their own paint schemes, which you host nowhere and sell never.

- **Product title form:** *Class / Model + designation + type*, e.g. “Class EF-4 ‘Little Joe’ Heavy Electric”, “Model M-10000 Early Streamliner”.
- **Ship the model in a plausible unlettered scheme** (builder's photo grey, or a plain colour) with the texture folders open; a day after release the community will have the real ones.
- **Routes:** describe the place and era (“Texas interurban, 1930s, street running”); street names and buildings are fine, business logos are not.
- **Screenshots** on the store are of your unlettered version. Community repaints in screenshots invite questions.
- **If a studio partnership** (official DLC on Steam) comes up later, you license the *compiled* product; keep the master .blend, textures and source scripts yours. The analysis covers the split in detail.

7 · The money: fees, taxes, what you keep

Planning figures from the analysis for one $40 flagship route, before any pre-order income. They assume a hosted store taking ~10% all-in and a Texas-based sole proprietor (0% state income tax).

Per release	Low · 500 units	Mid · 1,200 units	High · 2,500 units
Gross at $40	$20,000	$48,000	$100,000
Platform and payment fees (~10%)	−$2,000	−$4,800	−$10,000
Operating costs (software, hosting, domain)	−$1,500	−$1,500	−$1,500
Pre-tax profit	$16,500	$41,700	$88,500

Per release	Low · 500 units	Mid · 1,200 units	High · 2,500 units
Self-employment + federal income tax (~27–28%)	−$4,632	−$11,705	−$24,842
Take-home	**$11,868**	**$29,995**	**$63,658**

- **Self-employment tax** (Social Security + Medicare) is 15.3% on 92.35% of profit; **federal income tax** about 15% effective at these levels; a state with income tax would take a further 6–10%.
- **Set aside 30% of every payout** in a separate account the day it lands; pay quarterly estimated tax. This single habit is the difference between a business and a surprise.
- **Hours matter more than units:** the analysis works out ~$15/h at Mid and ~$32/h at High for a 2,000-hour route. A $15–25 locomotive built on reused scripts and bogies is a far better hour.
- **Fees are the price of not running checkout, tax and delivery yourself.** Moving to Shopify + Stripe (route B) at scale lowers the percentage but adds monthly plans and apps; revisit at 10+ products.
- **Expenses you can deduct:** Blender is free, but the games, DLC used for testing, reference books, the domain, hosting, a share of the PC. Keep receipts in one folder.

> **Steam instead?**
> Official DLC via a publisher means 30% to Valve plus the publisher's share, but visibility and automatic updates. The analysis's position: independent first, with the design-name catalogue and your own customer list; a partnership later is additive as long as you only license the compiled product.

8 · The e-mail list

The analysis calls this the first of three leverage points, and it costs nothing: every buyer and every demo downloader gives you an address. The storefront provider collects buyers' addresses by itself; for the free demo, use the provider's $0 product so the download goes through the same door. When product two launches, one mail reaches everyone who already trusts product one.

- One list, one message per release and one per major update; a dev-log digest at most monthly.
- Export the list from the provider every quarter (it is your customer list, not theirs).
- Put the sign-up on the landing page footer and the dev log; a sentence, not a pop-up.

9 · A weekly routine

When	What
Daily, 20 min	Support inbox; log anything repeated into the FAQ draft.
Weekly	Dev-log post with one image or a short clip from Blender or the game; check the greenlight bar; glance at the host's bandwidth and the provider's sales.
Per release	Package (§2) ▸ test-install ▸ product page ▸ web .glb into the pool ▸ mail the list ▸ post.

When	What
Monthly	Patch round-up (§3); set aside tax; export the customer list; back up the master .blend files and the site folder off the machine.
Quarterly	Estimated tax payment; look at which products sold and what the support cost; decide the next greenlight pitch.